

The Rebate-Ready Garden

A Rain Garden for Your Downspout

A shallow, planted basin that soaks up roof water, feeds pollinators, and is built to your local rebate program's rules.

10 × 5 FEET · 18 PLANTS · FULL SUN TO PART SHADE · WET AFTER STORMS, DRY BETWEEN

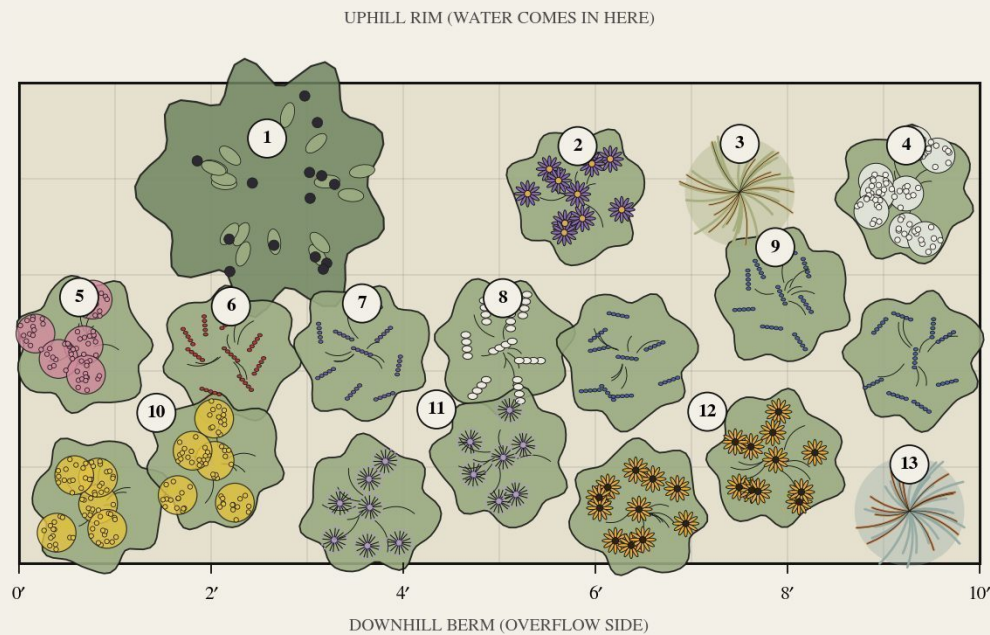


Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

A rain garden is a shallow bowl in the lawn, planted with flowers that don't mind wet feet. You run a downspout into it, and instead of sheeting off the driveway into the storm drain, the roof water sits for a day and sinks into the ground.

Every plant in this plan is native to District of Columbia. The middle of the bowl gets the plants that like it wettest: swamp milkweed, cardinal flower and blue vervain. The rim and the berm get tougher plants that can take a dry August.

Your local program may pay you back for building one. Page 4 shows what the program pays, what its rules are, and how this plan meets each one. Page 5 is the plant list and checklist, laid out the way the application asks for them.

Don't dig until your application is approved in writing, and call Miss Utility (811) first. After that it's a weekend of digging, a morning of planting, and a garden that waters itself.

WHAT TO BUY

- ☐ 1 Black chokeberry
- ☐ 1 New England aster
- ☐ 1 Switchgrass
- ☐ 1 Boneset
- ☐ 1 Swamp milkweed
- ☐ 1 Cardinal flower
- ☐ 1 Blue vervain
- ☐ 1 White turtlehead
- ☐ 3 Great blue lobelia
- ☐ 2 Golden alexanders
- ☐ 2 Wild bergamot
- ☐ 2 Black-eyed Susan
- ☐ 1 Little bluestem

(1)

(2)

(3)

(4)

(5)

(6)

(7)

(8)

(9)

(10)

(11)

(12)

(13)

18 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

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The Garden at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Black chokeberry

Aronia melanocarpa · 3–6 ft · Apr–May

Berries for birds in winter. Brilliant red fall color; very adaptable.

2. New England aster

Symphiotrichum novae-angliae · 3–6 ft · Aug–Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

3. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3–6 ft · Jul–Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

4. Boneset

Eupatorium perfoliatum · 2–4 ft · Jul–Sep

Wasps, flies and small bees. Leaves wrap around the stem, as if pierced.

5. Swamp milkweed

Asclepias incarnata · 3–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Clump-forming milkweed that behaves well in garden beds.

6. Cardinal flower

Lobelia cardinalis · 2–4 ft · Jul–Sep

Hummingbirds. Needs consistently wet soil. Short-lived; let it self-sow.

7. Blue vervain

Verbena hastata · 2–5 ft · Jul–Sep

Bees; seeds feed birds. Tall candelabra spikes for wet meadows.

8. White turtlehead

Chelone glabra · 2–3 ft · Aug–Oct

Baltimore checkerspot caterpillar host. Bumblebees climb right inside the flowers.

9. Great blue lobelia

Lobelia siphilitica · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Bumblebees. Pairs well with cardinal flower.

10. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1–3 ft · May–Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

11. Wild bergamot

Monarda fistulosa · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Bumblebees and hummingbird moths. Tolerates drought once established.

12. Black-eyed Susan

Rudbeckia hirta · 1–3 ft · Jun–Sep

Many small native bees. Short-lived but reseeds freely.

13. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Black chokeberry → Meadowsweet (*Spiraea alba*)

The Rebate-Ready Garden

What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Black chokeberry												
2. New England aster												
3. Switchgrass												
4. Boneset												
5. Swamp milkweed												
6. Cardinal flower												
7. Blue vervain												
8. White turtlehead												
9. Great blue lobelia												
10. Golden alexanders												
11. Wild bergamot												
12. Black-eyed Susan												
13. Little bluestem												

The Almanac: Looking After It

- BEFORE YOU DIG**
Get written approval, call 811, and do the perc test. If water is still standing after 36 hours, pick another spot.
- DIGGING**
Dig the bowl to the depth on page 4, and pile the soil on the downhill side to make the berm. Keep the bottom level so the water spreads out.
- PLANTING**
Plant in spring or early fall. Set wet-lovers in the bottom, rim plants on the sides. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

- MULCH**
Spread shredded hardwood mulch 2–3 in deep between plants, not against stems. No landscape fabric.
- THE FIRST YEAR**
Weed every couple of weeks, and check the inlet after big storms. If soil washes in, set a few flat stones where the water enters.
- KEEP IT WORKING**
Leave the stems up over winter for the birds and bees, then cut them back in late April. The program expects you to keep the garden up, so keep your receipts and photos.
- SAFETY**
Milkweed sap and lobelias are toxic if eaten (NC State Extension). Wear gloves when you cut milkweed, and keep pets and kids from chewing the plants.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

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Your Rebate Packet

Washington, DC · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Program rate \$41/sq ft · at most \$2,050 for 50 sq ft, if approved

Approval isn't guaranteed, and the rebate can never be more than what you actually spend, with itemized receipts; labor you do yourself doesn't count. Cap: \$3,000 per project. Minimum size for this project: 50 sq ft. Programs covered: RiverSmart Homes Rain Garden Rebate (DOEE, administered by the Alliance for the Chesapeake Bay). Who can apply: DC property owners. At least 400 sq ft of roof or paving must drain to the garden.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	50 sq ft of rain garden	✓ 50 sq ft
Drainage area	At least 400 sq ft of roof or paving drains to it	✓ See the worksheet below
Ratio	Garden area at least 1:10 of the area draining to it	✓ See the worksheet below
Plants	Only plants native to the Chesapeake Bay watershed	✓ Chesapeake-watershed natives, all listed for DC in USDA PLANTS; confirm against the program's list
Perc test	Perc Test Worksheet with the application	✓ Perc test steps below
Paperwork	Design sketch, invoice, maintenance agreement, before photos	✓ Fig. 1 plus the submission sheet

SIZING WORKSHEET

Measure the roof (and any paving) that drains to this downspout. It must be at least 400 sq ft, and the garden must be at least one-tenth of it. This 50 sq ft garden works for up to 500 sq ft of drainage area. Drainage area _____ sq ft ÷ 10 = _____ sq ft minimum garden.

PLACEMENT

Downhill of the house and well away from foundations (10 ft is the usual rule of thumb; confirm with the program). Not over buried utilities: call Miss Utility (811) before digging.

THE PERC TEST

Use the program's Perc Test Worksheet. 1. Dig a hole about 1 ft wide and 2 ft deep where the garden will go. 2. Fill it with water and let it drain. 3. Fill it again and set a ruler in it. 4. Record the time and depth until it's empty, on the worksheet. Photograph the ruler at the start and the end.

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Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Black chokeberry	<i>Aronia melanocarpa</i>	3 gal	1	48 in	DC
2	New England aster	<i>Symphotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
3	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
4	Boneset	<i>Eupatorium perfoliatum</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
5	Swamp milkweed	<i>Asclepias incarnata</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
6	Cardinal flower	<i>Lobelia cardinalis</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
7	Blue vervain	<i>Verbena hastata</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
8	White turtlehead	<i>Chelone glabra</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC
9	Great blue lobelia	<i>Lobelia siphilitica</i>	Quart	3	18 in	DC
10	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	2	18 in	DC
11	Wild bergamot	<i>Monarda fistulosa</i>	Quart	2	18 in	DC
12	Black-eyed Susan	<i>Rudbeckia hirta</i>	Quart	2	18 in	DC
13	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	1	18 in	DC

18 plants · 10 × 5 ft = 50 sq ft · 100% native to District of Columbia (USDA PLANTS) · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 0.4 cubic yards of shredded hardwood at 2.5 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Read the program's Homeowner Guide and Application Packet.
- ☐ Do the perc test and fill in the Perc Test Worksheet.
- ☐ Decide DIY or contractor; get an invoice or cost estimate.
- ☐ Send the application: design sketch, invoice, perc worksheet, signed Maintenance Agreement and before photos.
- ☐ Wait for pre-construction approval and inspection. Don't dig before it. Call 811 first.
- ☐ Build it, then tell the administrator it's complete and paid.
- ☐ Send after photos, the final invoice and the Project Completion Form; schedule the post-construction inspection.
- ☐ The rebate check arrives 2–6 weeks later.

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The spot before you start, from two angles
- ☐ The perc test hole with a ruler, full and after it drains
- ☐ The downspout and the path water will take
- ☐ The dug basin, before planting
- ☐ The finished garden, with plants labeled

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

The approval letter, every itemized receipt (plants, mulch, compost, rented tools), your photos, and this packet.

SOURCES

doee.dc.gov RiverSmart Homes rain garden rebate page (checked 9/30/26).

DISCLAIMER

This is an independent, general-information planting guide published by Orbital Desk LLC. It was not prepared for your property and is not professional landscape, engineering, site, grading, drainage, tax or legal advice. You are responsible for checking your own site, soil, drainage, setbacks, HOA rules, permits and buried utilities (call 811), and for following your program's current rules (checked Sept 30, 2026; programs change them). Only the program decides approval and payment; nothing here guarantees a rebate. Plants vary in availability, hardiness and growth, and some are toxic if eaten. Not affiliated with or endorsed by the District of Columbia, DOEE or the Alliance for the Chesapeake Bay. To the fullest extent the law allows, Orbital Desk LLC is not liable for any loss, damage, injury or denied rebate from using this guide, and its total liability is limited to the price you paid. For your personal use only; please don't resell or share. Refunds: 14 days from purchase (plan not yet submitted with a rebate application). Full Terms of Sale at rebatereadygarden.com/terms.html.